

# Entering Journalism in Times of Democratic Backsliding: Hong Kong Young Journalists' Career Decision and Persistence

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Hans T. F. Tse<sup>1</sup>, Francis L. F. Lee<sup>2</sup>,  
and Stephanie Z. Q. Yang<sup>2</sup>

## Abstract

This study examines why young people enter and stay in the field of journalism in a context where democratic backsliding has undermined the condition for meaningful and professional journalistic work. Adopting a life course perspective and through in-depth interviews with twenty six young journalists in Hong Kong, which recently experienced a process of rapid backsliding, the study attempts to understand how young people develop their interest in journalism and conceptions of what journalism should be through examining their initial imagination of journalism, experiences with major political events, journalism education, and role models. We categorized the interviewees as aspiring idealists, socialized idealists, and pragmatists. These journalists had different responses to the reality of journalistic work after joining the field—ranging from adaptive resilience to baseline maintenance. The analysis sheds light on the myriad ways young journalists react to a changing political environment and the sources of the resilience of liberal professional journalism.

## Keywords

young journalists, career choice, adaptive resilience, idealists versus pragmatists, democratic backsliding

<sup>1</sup>Independent Researcher, Hong Kong SAR

<sup>2</sup>School of Journalism and Communication, Chinese University of Hong Kong, Shatin, NT, Hong Kong SAR

## Corresponding Author:

Francis L. F. Lee, School of Journalism and Communication, Chinese University of Hong Kong, Shatin, NT, Hong Kong SAR.

Email: [francis\\_lee@cuhk.edu.hk](mailto:francis_lee@cuhk.edu.hk)

The long-term perpetuation of a journalistic professional community is premised on the availability of “new blood”—generations of young reporters who enter the field. Young people can be drawn to the profession by motivations ranging from a passion for writing to a desire to influence society, and research has shown that career motivations vary across national contexts and media systems (Hanusch et al. 2015; Mellado et al. 2013).

The question of why enter journalism becomes particularly intriguing when the field is in crisis. Against tremendous financial and digital disruptions of news work (Alexander et al. 2016), young journalists are more vulnerable to adverse working conditions (Reinardy 2011). The “journalism crisis” has arguably dampened the appeal of news work for aspiring journalists (Hanusch et al. 2015), posing further questions on why—and whether—they would embark on a journalism career.

In addition to technological and financial disruptions, journalism can also face a “political crisis” where press freedom is severely compromised by autocratization or democratic backsliding (Bermeo 2016; Diamond 2021). A decline in press freedom undermines the ability of the media to play some of its most important normative roles, such as monitoring the powerholders. The process could likewise undermine young people’s desire to join journalism to the extent that the ideal of public service underlines their intention to become a journalist. We may ask: How do young people in societies under democratic backsliding develop their imagination of journalism and decide to enter the field? How do they navigate and adjust to the much-less-than-ideal, “real world” news environment? What keeps them in the field?

Studies about journalism in non-democracies (Davis 2020; Moon 2023) rarely focus on young journalists and how the politics of press freedom take a toll on their career decisions. However, studying early-career journalists shall shed light on the possibility and limitations of journalistic resilience. This study shall contribute to our understanding of young journalists’ career decisions and development in varying political contexts. Empirically, this study focuses on Hong Kong, which has experienced a rapid contraction of press freedom since the Chinese state enacted the National Security Law (NSL) in 2020. Its ranking in Reporters Without Borders’ world press freedom index plummeted from 80th in 2020 and 2021 to 148th and 135th in 2022 and 2024, respectively. Post-NSL Hong Kong is therefore a suitable place to tackle the above questions.

## **The Formation of Aspiring Journalists**

Young journalists’ career motivations involve a mix of idealistic, practical, and personal considerations. Social status and material rewards typically play a lesser role in aspiring journalists’ motivations (Hovden et al. 2009). Many are attracted by the normative ideal of journalism or other features of news work, such as a flexible lifestyle and opportunities for creative expressions (Carpenter et al. 2016; Hanusch et al. 2016).

Some studies have examined the relative significance of idealism and private passions for would-be journalists. Hanusch et al. (2015) found that, among journalism students in eight countries, public service ideals are more important than private

motivations in Australia and the United States, and more so than in other countries. Hanna and Sanders (2007) found that, across the Atlantic, Nordic journalism students value public service ideals more than their UK counterparts do. The public service vs. market orientation of a country's media system (Hallin and Mancini 2004) may explain such national differences. That is, media systems and journalistic cultures are contextual factors shaping aspiring journalists' motivations.

A related issue is young aspiring journalists' understanding of the social role of professional media. Conceptually, young journalists' motivations should inform how they conceive journalism's social role. Strong believers of the public service ideal are likely to emphasize journalism's monitorial or watchdog role (Hanitzsch 2007), whereas students with more pragmatic motivations might see the media primarily as "content providers." Again, national differences exist. Studying seven countries, Mellado et al. (2013) found that Brazilian and Chilean students are more ardent believers in the watchdog role, arguably because of the countries' recent history of democratization (also see Bowe et al. 2021).

While the literature has usefully documented the motivations and beliefs of aspiring journalists, studies seldom explore how young people develop such ideas over their early life course (Elder 1998; Elder et al. 2003). This study does not aim at measuring young journalists' motivations and beliefs quantitatively; it tries to understand the contingent development of such motivations and beliefs as young people grow up.

## **A Life Course Approach to Career Decision**

This study draws inspiration from the life course theory developed by Elder (1998) and Mayer (2004, 2009). Life course refers to a human being's progression from birth to death (Clausen 1986). A key question of life course research is whether early conditions in lives, such as family background and socioeconomic conditions, are tied to later outcomes such as educational attainment, employment, and family formation (Elder 1998; Elder et al. 2003). Life course research also sees life outcomes as impacted by individual actions and characteristics, cultural and institutional processes, and structural conditions, thereby linking micro-, meso-, and macro-level analyses together (Mayer 2009).

Researchers have adopted the life course theory to study people's career choices and paths (Hostetler et al. 2007; Moen and Sweet 2004). This study argues that the theoretical perspective can also be employed to study the career decisions of young journalists. Journalism scholars have used a similar notion of life histories in understanding the changes of journalistic professionalism under the technological transformation (Meyers and Davidson 2013). Wahl-Jorgensen (2018) contends that following the life histories of journalists could offer both the vocabulary and the method in explaining the changes in their professional self-understanding. Applying the notion of life course to study young journalists' career decisions, however, requires us to look into the experiences they had before they join the field. Specifically, we are interested in how a young person's initial imagination about journalism, education, significant social events, and role models shape their interest in the field and career decision.

First, by initial imagination, we refer to the early views about what news work involves that were developed in everyday life during childhood. People consume news from an early age. Research shows that the family context shapes children's understanding of politics, public affairs, and journalism (McLeod 2000; Notten and Kraaykamp 2009). Young people may also encounter stories about journalism in the social arena. Many societies have legendary stories, often turned into popular and dramatic cultural products, about significant journalistic events (Schudson 1993). Moreover, adolescents in many societies have become increasingly active in public affairs (Earl et al. 2017; Hoffman and Jamal 2012). They could encounter "journalism" when participating in social affairs. All of these could spur young people's interest in the news and lead them to develop early ideas about journalism.

Second, formal education should be considered as aspiring journalists might enroll in journalism programs at tertiary institutions after forming an early interest. Studies have drawn contradictory conclusions about the influence of education. Splichal and Sparks (1994) argued that universal ethical and occupational standards were emerging among journalism students, but more recent studies found a diminishing influence of journalism education (Weaver et al. 2009). Again, important national differences are observed (Bjørnsen et al. 2007; Hanna and Sanders 2007). This study does not presume journalism education to have strong or weak influences on students. Rather, university education is treated as an institutional context in which aspiring journalists continue to develop their understanding of journalism.

Third, Mannheim's (1952) theory of generation postulates that people born in the same historical epoch can be subjected to the dominant influence of the time and take up certain common characteristics. Events happening in the adolescent years can be particularly influential because an adolescent is mature enough to understand social affairs yet naïve enough to be heavily influenced. This critical-years hypothesis has become prominent in the study of generational collective memories (Corning and Schuman 2013; Schuman and Scott 1989). For the present study, the important point is that professional aspirations and journalistic imaginations of a generation of youngsters can be shaped by significant social and political events, especially those occurring during their high school and university years.

Finally, journalistic ideals and values are abstract concepts, but aspiring journalists may encounter role models who have embodied the ideals and values. Wang and Lee (2014) found that many Hong Kong journalists name specific journalists or media organizations as their role models. There are systematic relationships between the role models and the individual characteristics of the journalists. While Wang and Lee (2014) did not focus on young journalists, the impact of role models in shaping the outlook of aspiring professionals was examined in other occupations (Basco and Reigart 2001; May 2009). Young journalists may encounter their role models at school when they start working in newsrooms, or through media consumption. Role models can shape the professional self-concept of people in specific fields (Gibson 2003).

The development of an early imagination of news work, journalism education, and contemporary social and political events cover three important aspects of what a young reporter may experience before joining the field, while the notion of a role model

allows aspiring journalists to articulate their conception of “the good journalist.” Together, they form a heuristic framework for examining how young people develop their intention to join journalism during their early life course.

## **Patterns of Persistence Amidst Uncertainties**

This study also examines how young journalists adapt to the “real world” of news work. Regardless of intentions, young journalists may not be prepared to endure the realistic hardships of journalism. Globally, the news media are battling financial crises (Starr 2012). Deteriorating financial conditions produce job loss and precarious employment (Ekdale et al. 2015). With limited bargaining power, young journalists could be more at risk of job insecurities (O'Donnell 2017). They are more susceptible to exhaustion and burnout and are more likely to express an intention to leave the field (Reinardy 2011).

Managing career expectations becomes imperative. Expectation management refers to the adjustment of one's assessment of the future with the aim of bringing expectations and aspirations closer to what is feasible. This process often involves news workers drawing upon one's inner emotional resources and social support, but it can also lead to a complete negation of expectations. Another possibility is a radical focus on the present: by giving full attention to the day-to-day routine, journalists bypass the psychological burden of future uncertainties to carry on daily news work (Goyanes and Rodríguez-Gómez 2021).

Among the few studies that focus on young journalists' career expectations, Nölleke et al. (2022) found that Austrian young journalists are prone to disappointment after entering the field. But instead of negating their expectations, Austrian young journalists endure periods of precarity and disappointment by adhering to the aspiration for autonomy—the idea that drove many of them into journalism in the first place. In other words, young journalists could draw upon their motivations as an emotional resource to enable resilience.

Notably, the studies discussed above are mainly conducted in stable democracies in which the main challenge facing young journalists is the inevitable ideal-reality gap and precarious labor conditions (Deuze 2007). This study focuses on a society undergoing rapid democratic backsliding, that is, “state-led debilitation or elimination of any of the political institutions that sustain an existing democracy” (Bermeo 2016: 5). As democratic backsliding is an ongoing process, young people can grow up, receive their education, and form their professional aspirations in a relatively liberal environment, only to find themselves working in a much more restricted field. This presents an additional and prominent source of discontent, posing a unique challenge of adaptation.

## **The Hong Kong Context**

In a city of seven million people, Hong Kong has seven schools/departments in tertiary institutions offering training in journalism or communication, providing a constant supply of graduates for news outlets. Despite not being a full democracy, Hong Kong

has enjoyed a substantial degree of civil liberties since the 1980s (Chan and Lee 1991). Hong Kong journalists adopted the liberal conception of journalistic professionalism as their legitimating creed (So and Chan 2007). The transfer of sovereignty to China in 1997 did not result in abrupt changes. Governed under the paradigm of liberal exceptionalism, the city enjoyed a degree of freedom unavailable to mainland cities (Chan et al. 2022).

However, the Chinese state also attempted to integrate the city into the national system gradually. China's export of autocratic influence over Hong Kong intensified in the 2010s (Fong 2021), generating increasing political tension and fueling pro-democracy protest mobilization. That culminated in the 2014 Umbrella Movement and the 2019 anti-extradition protests (Cheng et al. 2022). China responded to the 2019 protests by imposing a NSL onto the city in June 2020. Authorities also revoked a dormant colonial-era sedition law and, in March 2024, passed another set of national-security-related laws regarding offenses such as theft of state secrets and treason. These developments signified the state's legalization of political and press control in Hong Kong (Lee and Chan 2023).

Aspects of Hong Kong's democratic backsliding included the legal repression of protests and electoral reforms that substantially reduced the democratic elements of representative bodies. Critical journalism was subdued, with top news managers from the pro-democracy newspaper *Apple Daily* and online news site *Stand News* prosecuted (Lee and Chan 2023). Several mainstream news organizations experienced important personnel changes, signifying a movement toward conservatism.

Besides the political challenge, Hong Kong's journalistic field has already been plagued by existing problems of unfavorable working conditions. News organizations in Hong Kong are rarely highly profitable. The pay for journalists is generally low (Chan et al. 2012). Young university graduates can often find better-paying jobs such as teachers and civil servants, not to mention the more traditional professions. Adding long working hours and the need to work on public holidays to the picture, the Hong Kong journalism field has long had a high turnover rate. Many journalists find the need to seek employment in financially secure industries as they approach the age of marriage and child-rearing.

Despite the political and financial difficulties, journalism in the city has exhibited a degree of resilience. After the closure of *Apple Daily* and *Stand News*, several new online outlets have been established. They typically have a very small size and cannot match the prominence of their predecessors. They also have to engage in various kinds of risk management to navigate the new legal and political environment (Lee 2023). Yet they represent professional journalists' persistence. By the same token, while the media have reported a decline in the number of students majoring in journalism,<sup>1</sup> there are still young people entering the field. Indeed, the resilience of professional journalism in Hong Kong would depend on the continual availability of aspiring youngsters.

Zeng and George (2022) employed the concept of abeyance from social movement studies to examine how public-interest journalism may survive a hostile environment through the maintenance of networks, values, and identities by journalistic actors. Similarly, liberal journalism in Hong Kong, sustained by a community of practitioners

upholding the relevant values and identities, can be understood as entering an abeyance period. Nevertheless, journalism is also an occupational field. While journalism is a vocation to some, it can be merely a paid job to others (Hassid 2011). The pertinent question is not only whether young people would enter the field but also what aspirations young journalists have and whether they could maintain their aspirations after entering the field.

## Data and Method

The following analysis is based on twenty-six interviews with young reporters conducted between September 2022 and January 2023 as part of an ongoing project about the transformation of the city's press. The interviewees were recruited through snowballing. In our sample, the most and least experienced interviewees had been full-time journalists for four years and two months, respectively. Most of them entered the field after the NSL.

The interviewees came from twelve organizations—four newspapers, four broadcasters, three online outlets, and one international news agency. Other than the public broadcaster Radio Television Hong Kong, the Hong Kong news media are commercial. In terms of the political spectrum, since the closure of *Apple Daily* and *Stand News*, the liberal and oppositional end of the local press had been severed, while the remaining news organizations could still be located on a continuum ranging from the most unscrupulously pro-government to relatively professional and/or liberal-oriented. We deliberately interviewed more journalists working for relatively liberal organizations (seventeen of twenty six) because they had to face the most palpable impact of shrinking press freedom. All interviewees and their organizations are anonymized. Appendix Table A1 gives information about the interviewees.

The interviews were semi-structured and lasted for two hours on average. The interview protocol corresponds to the major topics discussed in the conceptual sections: (1) their initial interests in and ideas about journalism, (2) their decision to enter journalism schools (as most of them did) and their experiences in tertiary institutions, (3) their role models, if any, and (4) their experiences after entering the field. We ended by asking the interviewees when and/or under what conditions they would leave.

The authors conducted a close reading of the transcripts to identify patterns of career decision-making, role conception, and expectation management. Emerging themes were categorized iteratively as observations accumulated. During our analysis, it becomes clear that our interviewees are characterized by distinctive paths of development that shaped their professional imaginations and adjustment to reality. The interviewees can be differentiated into three types: the *aspiring idealists*, the *socialized idealists*, and the *pragmatists*. These categories are ideal types to which individual interviewees approach to different degrees. We classified thirteen interviewees as aspiring idealists, nine as socialized idealists, and four as pragmatists. The analysis thus begins by presenting the formation of the three types of journalists. We will then discuss how they adapt to the restrictive media environment.



## **The Aspiring Idealists**

Aspiring idealists are those who built their career decisions on early aspirations of what journalism can be and kept hold of their visions over the years. Family context matters to some aspiring idealists' initial imagination. Newspaper reporter Tina grew up in a politically active family. Her mother took and later accompanied her to protest events when she was small. She recalled relying on the news to help her understand complex political issues and named a satirical public affairs TV program as one of her favorite childhood pastimes. She was aware of the significance of the news as an information source from an early age.

Other interviewees derived an initial imagination about journalism through media representations and/or legendary stories. Newspaper reporter Brenda was impressed by the Watergate story when she was in secondary school. Coupled with her interests in writing, Brenda began to imagine a career in journalism. Similarly, radio reporter Kenneth was captivated by a local TV drama about reporters when he was in secondary school. In both cases, the young reporter's initial imagination came from an early encounter with cultural representations, which often portray the values of journalism dramatically and affirmatively.

Some interviewees gradually learn about prominent journalists who embody specific professional values or ideals. Aspiring idealists were typically able to name their role models. Financial reporter Edith expressed a keen interest in investigative journalism. When asked about the root of that interest, she quickly named Chai Jing, a renowned Chinese journalist famous for her investigative documentary on China's air pollution problem. Edith's idea of meaningful journalism closely resembled Chai's work—investigative intervention on socially significant issues. Keith, a newspaper reporter, mentioned a veteran print journalist as his role model. For Keith, his role model represented the “old guards’ way”—sensitive about news, stubborn about truth, and unyielding about quality.

Nonetheless, the single most significant factor that led the aspiring idealists to choose journalism—as a university major or career option—was the seventy-nine-day Umbrella Movement in 2014 (Lee and Chan 2018). The news media played a prominent role in helping our interviewees follow and understand the event. Some interviewees mentioned key moments during the movement that affected their imagination of journalism. Nancy mentioned that watching the police firing tear gas at the protesting crowd on television motivated her to consider becoming a reporter. Similarly, broadcast journalist Nora called the “dark corner incident,” in which a TV station filmed the police beating a handcuffed protester, for consolidating her intention to become a reporter.

## **The Socialized Idealists**

Differing from aspiring idealists who formed their initial normative understanding of journalism before entering universities, the socialized idealists developed their normative beliefs through interacting with journalism educators and/or doing actual



reporting. Their role conception and career motivation came from a process of professional socialization.

Young reporters in this category were indecisive about a journalism career when they entered college. In Hong Kong, many university programs simultaneously offer education on journalism, advertising, public relations, and creative media. Hence there is a range of media-related career options. Newspaper reporter Todd did not intend to become a reporter when entering journalism school, but he learned to appreciate reporting through hands-on journalism assignments. Broadcast journalist Bella was originally inclined toward advertising but grew passionate about news after making a photo story about local communities.

While aspiring journalists had relatively little to say regarding the impact of journalism education on themselves, the socialized idealists often identified their teachers as influential figures. Bella identified a lecturer—also a veteran journalist—as her role model. She said the lecturer “would talk in-depth about the principles; a reporter should be meticulous, critical, and concerned about what concerns the citizens.” Notably, Bella did not study at the institution where her role model taught, but she went to audit the lecturer’s courses. In other words, the influence of journalism education does not necessarily come from the formal curriculum. Instead, tertiary institutions constitute a context for exploration, where notable teachers can be a source of moral support and inspiration.

Internships are often a part of journalism education and where students first participate in “real world” news production. Senior newsroom colleagues are crucial in transferring knowledge and values. Newspaper reporter Zenia recalled being impressed by a senior colleague’s meticulous attention to detail and unwavering concentration in investigation during her internship at an international news agency. Radio reporter Dora, who interned at a China news desk, recalled how she was inspired by her senior colleagues’ ability to confront powerholders. The internships consolidated both interviewees’ dedication to journalism.

Just as the Umbrella Movement was a major episode for the aspiring idealists, the anti-extradition movement in 2019 was a significant episode for the socialized idealists. Instead of being onlookers or participants, the socialized idealists typically experienced the 2019 protests as reporters. Some interviewees’ engagement in news reporting in 2019 was almost accidental. Lilian, for instance, was working in a non-editorial role for a local newspaper, but the sheer scale of the protests and the lack of human resources pushed her to the frontline. Similarly, Molly had no intention to pursue a journalism career before she was invited by an online outlet to contribute feature stories in 2019.

Our interviewees derived different “lessons” from the anti-extradition protests. The proliferation of misinformation during the protests led Brenda to believe that people had to “rely on [. . .] *legit* news media for information.” Todd worked as a student reporter and saw the behavior of many “non-professional reporters” (e.g., citizen journalists and fellow student reporters) as “inappropriate.” He started to align himself with the image of a non-partisan reporter, who would be neither friends nor foes with the authorities or the protesters. Dora said covering the protests had fostered her belief

of journalism as “endowed with power—to get close to the situation, to record the event truthfully.” Despite such differences, the experience triggered several interviewees’ intentions to pursue a journalism career.

## The Pragmatists

While most of our interviewees are idealistic in the sense that they emphasize certain normative conceptions of how journalists should serve the public, pragmatists are less concerned about the normative social roles of journalism. They are attracted by practical aspects of the field, such as fun, flexible working conditions, and chances of social networking and knowledge accumulation. The pragmatists gave relatively lukewarm answers to questions about the meaning of their job, and they might exhibit a somewhat uncertain attitude when asked to reflect upon their decision to enter the field.

Newspaper reporter Lester is an example. He described reading about scandal reports surrounding the 2012 Chief Executive Election in Hong Kong when he was small and thought journalism was “cool.” That motivated him to pursue a journalism degree, but he soon discovered that he was less passionate than his peers about the news. Even the experience of interning during the anti-extradition protests did not influence him significantly. When asked about his decision to enter the field, Lester replied: “I didn’t think about other options. I simply followed the path.” Similarly, broadcast journalist Charles said: “It was four years [of journalism education] after all. It’d be wasteful [. . .] Switching to another industry is unlikely because it’d be difficult to compete with graduates trained for that.” The cases of Lester and Charles suggest the presence of “path dependency” for some interviewees. Joining the field can be merely a natural extension of a journalism degree. There is a pragmatic undertone throughout: it is advisable to adhere to a career path one has invested in.

The pragmatists are also distinctive as their discourses about news work focused much more on craftsmanship than on values and meanings. This is clear when they talked about their role models. Some interviewees, like Charles and Britney, initially said that they had no role models. When pressed, they said they looked up to colleagues at work, not because of how their colleagues inspired them, but because the senior colleagues were more competent. Broadcast journalist Isaac, in particular, aspired to be a news anchor since childhood and was eloquent about the presentational skills of a good anchor. He named a list of notable anchors as his role models, giving detailed elaboration on the tricks of the trade.

The above discussion should be qualified by the fact that the pragmatists did acknowledge the value of journalism and recognize the worsening condition of press freedom. Despite his vague articulation of the social roles of journalism, Lester insisted that a reporter can contribute to society. Isaac criticized an incident in which a local broadcaster fired dozens of competent journalists in the name of cost-cutting. Nonetheless, the pragmatists’ lack of strong idealism rendered them more likely to find the working conditions of pro-government media acceptable. Lester said he would want to try investigative journalism in an *ideal world*, but he applied for the position of education reporter in a pro-government newspaper, which he believed to be a

“tolerable” position. Similarly, Isaac was working at the financial news desk even though he was interested in local social news, saying: “things are easier [. . .] going to grand restaurants or hotels, at least not as hectic.”

## **After Entrance: Adaptive Resilience and Baseline Maintenance**

Most of our interviewees entered the field just as or after the NSL was imposed in 2020. A media crackdown ensued in 2021 (Lee 2023). Directly experiencing the changes, how did young reporters adjust and adapt? Notwithstanding individual variations, we can summarize our interviewees’ responses to reality and approaches to mitigate frustrations into two major categories: adaptive resilience and baseline maintenance.

Adaptive resilience refers to how journalists insist on work they see as meaningful, though acknowledging that they could do so only by adapting to the environment. For the young journalists in post-NSL Hong Kong, adaptation begins by carefully choosing the news organization to work for. Not surprisingly, both aspiring and socialized idealists tended to seek jobs in relatively liberal-oriented newsrooms. For example, Tina applied to be a court reporter in a liberal newspaper, believing that the paper was one of the few organizations where meaningful journalism could still be achieved.

Speaking of their assessment of press freedom in Hong Kong, the interviewees generally noticed the legal risks associated with critical reporting, the intensifying self-censorship and newsroom controls, and the shattering of civil society. However, not all organizations face the same degree of pressure and risks. Compared with conservative newsrooms in which self-censorship has long been routinized (Au 2017), self-censorship and newsroom controls can be felt more palpably in liberal-oriented news organizations. For instance, Kitty recounted an incident in which her story about a sensitive issue was unexpectedly withdrawn. Kitty confronted her editor, but only received a vague account of the need for “risk avoidance.”

Young reporters are generally less worried about legal risks because top managers would bear the legal responsibilities. But young reporters also need to adapt to the new “rules of the game.” Multiple interviewees stressed the need for caution, though the precise acts of adaptation varied across newsrooms. Quinn said editors have demanded reporters to back contentious claims with strong factual evidence. Kenneth said he needed to be extra cautious when submitting questions to and handling quotes from government officials. Various interviewees said they might soften the tone of the writing and/or wait for the government’s response before running a story. Nonetheless, the young journalists typically saw these compromises as necessary to publicize certain critical information.

Mentally, some young reporters developed a “presentist” framework when talking about the future (Goyanes and Rodríguez-Gómez 2021). Many interviewees expressed a “do-it-while-you-can” attitude when asked about the purpose of doing journalism under uncertain conditions. Many believed that press freedom would continue to

worsen, and they did not presume that they would remain in the field for long. This perception, however, compelled our interviewees to make use of the remaining room for professional reporting. As Nancy put it: “exactly because of the NSL, there is not much time left, and that’s why I persist.”

This mindset is perhaps most clearly demonstrated by several interviewees who chose to join *Apple Daily* and *Stand News* in 2021 (before the newsrooms were forced to shut down), despite knowing that the companies were at risk. One ex-*Apple Daily* reporter said: “It was a matter of do-it-while-you-can [because] I thought there would only be fewer outlets [like *Apple Daily*].” Rumors about the upcoming prosecution of the companies were not a deterrent to these young reporters, but a call for action. In our sample, the interviewees who joined these two organizations were arguably the most adamant to persist and held the strongest opinion against self-censorship in the name of adaptation.

In contrast to adaptive resilience, baseline maintenance refers to the withholding of normative expectations, avoiding “risky” areas of journalism, and maintaining a minimal sense of professionalism. For instance, pragmatists Lester and Isaac chose positions in pro-government media less ruffled by the political change. To both, such positions were acceptable as long as they did not require blatant, propagandist writing. Lester also recalled several encounters in which he argued against his superior’s decision to withhold specific stories. There was still a professional bottom line that pragmatists tried not to forfeit.

Notably, the strategic topical selection is common to young reporters who exercised baseline maintenance. Charles diverted his attention from political news to news about housing and transportation issues. He said professional journalism could still be properly conducted on such topics. Our interviewees articulated the coping strategy of baseline maintenance as guarding a professional baseline while resorting to areas of work that were considered “acceptable” or “tolerable.”

Not surprisingly, the aspiring and socialized idealists were more likely to exhibit adaptive resilience, whereas the pragmatists were more likely to exhibit baseline maintenance. But there can be exceptions. Edith is a case in point. Her ability to articulate journalistic aspirations, embodied by a clearly identified role model, made us categorize her as an aspiring idealist. In her career, Edith progressed from a local newspaper’s financial desk to an international financial news agency. This trajectory would normally be seen in Hong Kong as a positive career development. However, Edith noted that her decision to focus on financial news was based on risk avoidance and the lure of a stable income. She explicitly said she no longer thought about realizing the public service ideal of journalism, and that she was only doing a salaried job.

## Concluding Discussion

This study aims to enrich our understanding of young journalists’ decision to enter the industry and their persistence under democratic backsliding. Post-NSL Hong Kong offers a suitable case in which an abrupt decline in press freedom aggravated a journalistic crisis characterized by technological and financial disruptions. Our analysis

identified three types of young journalists: the aspiring idealists, the socialized idealists, and the pragmatists. Each group has distinctive formative experiences. They varied in terms of the relative significance of public service ideals and private passions, the relevance of journalism education, the choice of role models, and the influence of contemporary political events.

Furthermore, this study identifies two ways young journalists handle the political challenges of news work under adverse conditions. Adaptive resilience and baseline maintenance represent two poles of a spectrum. At one end are young reporters who engage in professional and critical reporting, while adapting to the emerging reality of political control and intensified censorship. At the other end are journalists who put aside the normative role and treat journalism as a salaried job, though also trying to maintain professional bottom lines regarding what they would or would not do.

This study contributes to our understanding of journalistic resilience in contemporary Hong Kong. Despite the intensification of press control (Lee and Chan 2023), professional journalism did not completely disappear. As noted in the conceptual discussion, liberal journalism in Hong Kong can be considered as entering a period of abeyance, and the challenge is to maintain the relevant values, goals, and identities. Surviving the potentially very lengthy abeyance period would require the availability of new blood. This article addresses the question of where the new blood comes from and what their characters are. Our analysis showed that, despite the worsening condition, those who remain committed to a journalistic career can still possess substantive aspirations, even though they must accept the necessity of some kinds of adaptation and trade-offs.

The continual presence of aspiring and socialized idealists who exhibit adaptive resilience provides a source of resilience to the embattled liberal journalism in Hong Kong. In fact, the phenomenon of adaptive resilience is pertinent not only to how journalists navigate the process of backsliding. Most recently, scholars have also started to interrogate into adaptive resilience of pro-democracy citizens and civil society activists in Hong Kong (Lee et al. 2024). This study thus adds to the literature on how the liberal and pro-democracy section of society adapts to autocratization.

Certainly, the exact proportions of the three types of young journalists in Hong Kong remain unknown. The present study has a large proportion of aspiring or socialized idealists, but this arguably results from the project's attempt to recruit more journalists from the relatively liberal-oriented newsrooms. Moreover, as pragmatists are marked by their weak emphasis on public service, their interest in participating in a research project is also understandably weaker. It is also important to note that some pro-government newsrooms had tight restrictions regarding employees' participation in research. These factors could create a "bias" toward idealists in our sample. Some might wonder if the pragmatists, or what Hassid (2011) called "workaday journalists," would become the mainstream. This study does not aim at deriving quantitative estimations, which can be the goal of future studies. However, for the persistence of liberal journalism, the continual presence of aspiring young journalists could be significant even if they only constitute a minority.

Beyond the Hong Kong context, this study contributes to the study of young journalists in several ways. First, in contrast to extant studies that identify the professional and personal motivations of would-be journalists and students (Hanusch et al. 2015; Mellado et al. 2013), this study adopts a life course approach (Elder 1998) that emphasizes the development of young people's early understanding of and interest in the field. The examination of the interviewees' initial imagination, educational experience, role models, and observations of and participation in political events helped us construct holistic and nuanced accounts of the different paths through which young people come to the industry. The same approach can be applied to studying young journalists in other contexts.

In particular, the present analysis highlighted the influence of significant political events on young people's interest in journalism. Through significant events, young people come up with articulations of the news media's roles in public affairs. Specifically, Hong Kong in the 2010s was marked by the presence of two spectacular protest campaigns. The case of Hong Kong thus points to the plausibly close connections between ferments in society and the development of the journalistic community. Besides, as the conceptual section has noted, significant events can be particularly influential to adolescents (Mannheim 1952). How significant events shape the character of a generation of journalists can be an issue to pursue in future studies (Bowe et al. 2021).

While the conceptual discussion has highlighted journalism education as an important factor in the formation of young journalists, neither the aspiring idealists nor the pragmatists talked much about how journalism education influenced them. There was even a sentiment from many interviewees that university education is not-so-practical; the best way to learn to become a journalist is in-the-field experience. However, this observation should not be concluded as a dismissal of journalism education. Some interviewees had named university teachers as role models. In our analysis, the influence of journalism education is rooted not in the formal curriculum; instead, tertiary institutions constitute a context in which young people encounter reporting assignments, work opportunities, and respectable seniors, preparing them for a journalism career.

Following the above paragraph, another conceptual issue worth highlighting is the utility of examining role models. The notion of role models has seldom been addressed systematically in journalism studies (Wang and Lee 2014), but research about other professions has suggested the significance of role models in shaping people's professional self-understanding. This study, strictly speaking, cannot prove that the choice of role models influenced young people's conception of journalism, but it shows that inviting young journalists to talk about role models can help clarify and substantiate their ideas.

A couple of limitations of the present study need to be noted. In addition to the possible "sampling bias" toward the more idealistic journalists, the analysis does not include those who have already left the field. On the one hand, the non-inclusion is justified given the analysis's focus on why young people joined and stayed in journalism. On the other hand, a contrast between those who joined and those who exited

could further enrich our understanding of how young people consider journalism as a career.

One peculiarity of young journalists examined in this study is that they did experience the pre-NSL Hong Kong society and the major protest events in the 2010s. As political control is tightened, major protest campaigns might not occur in the foreseeable future, and many senior journalists have left the field. The conditions that helped produce the aspiring idealists and socialized idealists in this study have been weakened. Future research is needed to see if the formation of young journalists will change under continual social transformation.

To conclude, this study has built a conceptual framework that can help us understand the changing or unchanging characters of the journalism profession. Under democratic backsliding, some young people continue to develop idealistic aspirations about journalism, though some adopt a pragmatic attitude and take journalism only as a job. The idealists could exhibit adaptive resilience after entrance, which constitutes part of the resilience of professional journalism in unfavorable circumstances.

## Appendix

**Table A1.** List of Interviewees.

| Pseudonym | Years<br>in field | Media type | Categorization | Pseudonym | Years<br>in field | Media type    | Categorization |
|-----------|-------------------|------------|----------------|-----------|-------------------|---------------|----------------|
| Quinn     | 4                 | Newspaper  | AI             | Bella     | 1                 | Television    | SI             |
| Kitty     | 2                 | Newspaper  | AI             | Nora      | 2                 | Television    | AI             |
| Nancy     | 3                 | Newspaper  | AI             | Lilith    | 2                 | Television    | AI             |
| Brenda    | 3                 | Newspaper  | AI             | Kenneth   | 1                 | Radio         | AI             |
| Leslie    | 2                 | Newspaper  | SI             | Dora      | 1                 | Radio         | SI             |
| Tina      | 1                 | Newspaper  | AI             | Zena      | 0.5               | Online media  | AI             |
| Xander    | 1                 | Newspaper  | SI             | Teddy     | 2                 | Online media  | SI             |
| Louis     | 2                 | Newspaper  | AI             | Edith     | 3                 | International | AI             |
| Una       | 2                 | Newspaper  | AI             | Zenia     | 1.5               | Newspaper     | SI             |
| Lester    | 1                 | Newspaper  | P              | Lilian    | 2                 | Newspaper     | SI             |
| Keith     | 1                 | Newspaper  | AI             | Britney   | 2 months          | Online media  | P              |
| Todd      | 1                 | Television | SI             | Isaac     | 1                 | Television    | P              |
| Charles   | 1                 | Television | P              | Molly     | 2                 | Online media  | SI             |

Note. AI = Aspiring Idealists; SI = Socialized Idealists; P = Pragmatists.

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## ORCID iDs

Hans T. F. Tse  <https://orcid.org/0000-0003-0271-611X>

Francis L. F. Lee  <https://orcid.org/0000-0003-1587-4950>

Stephanie Z. Q. Yang  <https://orcid.org/0009-0003-3923-6256>

## Note

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### Author Biographies

**Hans T. F. Tse** is an independent researcher and a journalist in Hong Kong. He has an M.Phil degree in communication from the Chinese University of Hong Kong and his research focuses on Hong Kong's press freedom and social movements.

**Francis L. F. Lee** is a professor at the School of Journalism and Communication at the Chinese University of Hong Kong. His current research examines press freedom and political change as well as media and collective memory of political events.

**Stephanie Z. Q. Yang** is an M.Phil student at the School of Journalism and Communication at the Chinese University of Hong Kong. Her research focuses on journalism studies and political communication in Hong Kong.